

FEDERAL LAUNCH KIT · CAPABILITY STATEMENT

How to Write a Federal Capability Statement.

INSIDE THIS MANUAL ↓

- ✓ **1-page rule** · Two pages max. Never longer.
- ✓ **5 sections** · Overview, competencies, diffs, past perf, certs
- ✓ **Strong vs weak** · Side-by-side examples per section
- ✓ **6-month rule** · When to refresh, what to change

THE FOUR-TOOL SYSTEM

FREE · LETTER PDF

01

1-page rule

Two pages max. Never longer.

02

5 sections

Overview, competencies, diffs, past perf, certs

03

Strong vs weak

Side-by-side examples per section

04

6-month rule

When to refresh, what to change

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The single most-used document in federal contracting.

[/ HOW TO USE](#)

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	Why a contracting officer keeps yours or trashes it in 12 seconds.	

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Boarding Team

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A LETTER TO THE OPERATOR

Most cap statements get thrown out in the first 12 seconds.

A contracting officer at a mid-sized DoD command told me she gets about forty cap statements a week from small businesses chasing her NAICS. She keeps maybe three. The rest go in a folder she never opens again.

The three she keeps all do the same thing: they tell her in the first paragraph what the company does, who they do it for, and one number that proves they can actually do it. That's it. No mission statement. No 'committed to excellence.' No stock photos of handshakes.

I've written and rewritten about two hundred cap statements over the last few years. The ones that open doors are usually shorter than the ones that don't. They use real contract numbers. They list real references with real phone numbers. They sit on one page.

This guide is the version of the brief I give every client before they redo theirs. Five sections, the layout rules, and side-by-side examples of strong vs weak language so you can tell which one you've written.

A. Schuler

30 MIN · NO PITCH

Book a 30-min cap statement review

<https://meetings-na2.hubspot.com/americurial/intro-call>

Book the call →

PART ONE · THE FIVE SECTIONS

Five sections. One page. No filler.

Every federal cap statement uses the same five sections in roughly the same order: Company Overview, Core Competencies, Differentiators, Past Performance, Certifications & Contact. That part isn't optional.

What is optional is how you fill them. The next three pages cover the first three sections, with side-by-side examples of language that works and language that gets you ignored.

SECTION 1 • COMPANY OVERVIEW

Two to four sentences. Three questions, in order.

The overview lives at the top of the page. It's the part a contracting officer reads before they decide whether to keep scrolling. It must answer three questions in sequence, in the same order, every time:

- 01 **What do you do?** Your core service, not your mission statement.
- 02 **Who do you serve?** Specific agencies or mission areas if possible.
- 03 **What's the proof?** One concrete number that establishes credibility.

STRONG EXAMPLE

"Meridian Defense Group provides cybersecurity and network operations services to DoD and Intelligence Community clients. We hold active Secret and TS/SCI cleared staff on 6 current federal contracts totaling \$4.2M in active performance."

WEAK EXAMPLE — AVOID

"We are a dynamic small business committed to excellence in delivering solutions to our valued government clients."

This says nothing concrete. Every bad cap statement reads like this. The CO has read it forty times this week.

WHY THIS WORKS

The strong version answers all three questions in one sentence each. "Cybersecurity and network ops" (what). "DoD and IC" (who). "6 contracts, \$4.2M" (proof). A reader who only gets through the first paragraph still knows whether to call you.

SECTION 2 • CORE COMPETENCIES

Four to six specific capabilities. Make each one a sentence, not a label.

This is the section every cap statement gets lazy on. People list five generic categories and move on. The contracting officer scanning your document needs to know *exactly* what you do — not what bucket you fit in.

Every competency line should be:

- **Specific** enough that a contracting officer knows what you actually do
- **Measurable** where possible — scale, clearance level, technology stack
- **Relevant** to the agency's mission or a known procurement type

WEAK (DON'T DO THIS)	STRONG (DO THIS)
IT Support Services	Tier 2/3 helpdesk supporting 10,000+ end users on NIPR and SIPR networks
Construction Management	Design-Build construction management for healthcare and laboratory facilities, LEED certified
Consulting Services	Organizational redesign and M&A integration for federal agencies undergoing BRAC consolidation
Cybersecurity	Zero Trust Architecture implementation, CMMC Level 2 consulting, and FISMA compliance audits
Logistics	OCNUS supply chain coordination for 3 active DLA contracts across CENTCOM and AFRICOM AORs

FIELD TIP

Read each line aloud and ask: *could ten other companies write this exact sentence?* If yes, it's still too generic. Add the scale, the customer, or the technology stack until only you could have written it.

SECTION 3 • DIFFERENTIATORS

Where most cap statements collapse. Use the formula.

Differentiators are supposed to tell a contracting officer why you, specifically, can do this work better than the other forty cap statements on her desk. Most don't. Most list "customer focus" and "quality work" — which isn't a differentiator, it's the minimum bar.

Use this formula on every bullet:

[Unique attribute] + [Evidence] + [Benefit to the agency]

Three examples that actually do the work:

- **Only SDVOSB in the mid-Atlantic with both CMMC Level 2 certification AND TS/SCI cleared staff** available for short-notice task orders. (Attribute: unique combo. Evidence: certifications. Benefit: speed.)
- **Proprietary 4-phase O&M transition methodology reduced facility downtime 34% on our last 3 federal handovers** — referenced in our CPARS narratives. (Attribute: methodology. Evidence: number + CPARS. Benefit: lower transition risk.)
- **12-year consecutive CPARS rating of 'Exceptional' across 18 federal contracts** — available upon request. (Attribute: track record. Evidence: CPARS. Benefit: low performance risk.)

WHAT TO STRIP

Cut anything that sounds like a brochure: "customer focused," "quality driven," "results oriented," "committed to excellence," "trusted partner." None of those words mean anything to a contracting officer because every other vendor uses them.

If you can replace the word with its opposite and the sentence still sounds like marketing, the word isn't doing any work.

PART TWO • PROOF + DESIGN

Past performance, certifications, and the layout rules that make it look professional.

Sections 4 and 5 are where you prove the claims you made on page one. Past performance shows you've done this before. Certifications show you're verified to do it. Without both, the rest of the document is just marketing.

The last page covers the layout discipline that separates a cap statement that looks like a contractor's brochure from one that looks like a vendor a CO will actually call back.

SECTION 4 • PAST PERFORMANCE

Three to five contracts. The fields a CO actually checks.

Past performance turns a cap statement from a brochure into a vendor file. List three to five contracts, recent first. Include every field below. If you can't fill a field, leave the contract out — a half-listed contract is worse than no contract.

FIELD	WHAT TO INCLUDE
Contracting agency	Customer name. If you were a sub, list the prime AND the federal agency the prime served.
Contract number	The actual contract or task order number. CO will look it up in FPDS.
Contract value	Your share — not the total prime value if you were a sub.
Period of performance	MM/YY to MM/YY. "Ongoing" is fine if current.
NAICS code	The NAICS the contract was awarded under. Shows relevance to the opportunity.
Reference POC	Name, title, phone, email. Someone who will actually pick up.

NO FEDERAL PAST PERFORMANCE YET?

Don't fake it. List 2-3 commercial projects, frame them with federal relevance, and include real references. See **'06 — Converting Commercial Work to Federal Past Performance'** for the full reframing playbook.

FIELD TIP

Call every POC on your reference list every six months. One in three will have moved in a year — a dead reference is worse than no reference.

SECTION 5 • CERTIFICATIONS & CONTACT

Only list what you actually hold.

Certifications go in the bottom-right corner of a one-page layout. Two rules: only list what you can prove, and use the verified source (not a self-cert) when one exists. A false claim here is federal certification fraud.

CERTIFICATION	WHAT COUNTS AS PROOF
Active SAM.gov registration	Required for every federal vendor. CAGE + UEI on the cap statement.
Small Business designation	NAICS-by-NAICS — show the codes you qualify under.
SDVOSB / VOSB	VetCert verified. Self-cert is no longer valid.
8(a)	Only if SBA-approved. Include cert date + program end date.
HUBZone	Only if SBA-certified. Recertify annually or status drops.
WOSB / EDWOSB	SAM self-cert is legally sufficient — third-party is stronger.
Security clearances	List clearance held by key staff. "5 staff with TS/SCI" beats "cleared."
Industry certs	ISO 9001, CMMC, PMP, OSHA, LEED. Include certifying body + renewal year.

CONTACT BLOCK

Company name, address, phone, email, website, SAM UEI, CAGE code, primary NAICS. Large enough to read at a glance.

LAYOUT & DESIGN RULES

It's a marketing document. Make it look like one.

A cap statement is the cover letter to every federal opportunity you'll ever chase. Break the rules below and your document goes in the trash pile regardless of how good the content is.

ELEMENT	GUIDELINE
Length	One page preferred. Two pages absolute maximum. Never three.
Logo	Top-left. Vector format at print resolution — no pixelated PNGs.
Font	One font family, max two weights. 10-12pt body, 14-16pt headers.
Color	Match your brand. One consistent accent color for headers and bars.
Columns	Two columns — competencies left, past performance right.
Contact	Bottom of page. Large enough to read at arm's length.
File format	Send as PDF, never Word. <code>CompanyName_CapStatement_2026.pdf</code>
Update frequency	Every 6 months, or immediately after a major new award.

REFRESH CADENCE + FINAL CHECK

Calendar reminder for January 1 and July 1. Re-verify every past performance reference, every certification expiry, every NAICS. A stale cap statement is a missed contract.

Then hand it to someone who's never seen your company. Give them 30 seconds. If they can't tell you what you do, who you do it for, and why the government should hire you — rewrite the overview.

WHAT'S NEXT

Stop staring at a blank doc. Let the engine **draft** it.

CapturePilot's Capability Statement builder pulls your SAM.gov registration, past awards, and certifications, then drafts a one-page cap statement following the rules in this guide. Edit in-app or export to PDF. Free 14-day trial. No card.

Get the full Federal Launch Kit

[HTTPS://WWW.CAPTUREPILOT.COM/STARTUP-PACK](https://www.capturepilot.com/startup-pack)